



Should purchasers/funders and control agencies compare initiatives only on the basis of 'what works'?

In a 'What Works', outcomes-orientated world, it seems sensible for purchasers/funders and control agencies to compare initiatives based on 'What Works' and only fund initiatives which can robustly prove an impact on high-level outcomes. This has been encouraged by the growth of meta-analyses, where you statistically summarize a number of different studies to get a robust average effect-size, which is seen as a good indication of whether or not an initiative 'works'.

In theory, this all sounds good. However, it is more difficult to prove that some agencies, providers, policies or initiatives 'work' than to prove that others do. Also, more evaluation research has been done on some types of initiatives than others. A purchaser/funder implementing an unsophisticated What Works' funding approach can inadvertently create a bias in its selection of initiatives to fund.

For instance, it is usually the case that initiatives that use an individual-focused approach - e.g. individual casework, therapy or school-based designs - are easier to evaluate than initiatives that take more societal-level approaches - e.g. community-level initiatives. With the first type of initiative, you can often randomly allocate individuals to an intervention or a control group and use an experimental impact evaluation design. See the Impact Evaluation Design Types Tool (G9).

It is generally much harder, but not necessarily impossible, to do experiments on community-level initiatives. As a result, there is likely to be less robust experimental impact evaluation evidence on whether community-level initiatives work. It should be noted that community-level interventions often cost less on a per-person basis than individual-level interventions. So, even if a community-led intervention has been shown to be less effective for each individual exposed to it, the fact that it can reach a larger number of people can make it more cost-effective than an individual-focused initiative that has a larger effect size but less reach.

It is also the case that some initiatives, for example, those focused on indigenous people, are likely to have had less research done on them and often with inappropriate methodologies. Therefore, they will not stack up as well if funders use a simplistic approach of only funding 'What Works'.